MIRROR: A Hierarchical Benchmark for Metacognitive Calibration in Large Language Models

Anonymous Authors
NeurIPS 2026 Datasets and Benchmarks Track

Abstract

We introduce MIRROR (Metacognitive Integrity and Recursive Reasoning in Operationalized Response), a benchmark comprising eight experiments across four metacognitive levels that evaluates whether large language models can use self-knowledge to make better decisions. We evaluate 16 models from 8 labs across approximately 250,000 evaluation instances using five independent behavioral measurement channels. We find two phenomena with direct implications for agentic deployment: (1) compositional self-prediction fails universally—the Compositional Calibration Error ranges from 0.500 to 0.943 across 15 models, and the Metacognitive Convergence Index is 0.000, and (2) models possess accurate domain-specific self-knowledge but systematically fail to translate it into appropriate agentic action-selection—external metacognitive control reduces the Confident Failure Rate from 0.562 to 0.214, a 62% reduction. Providing models with their own calibration scores produces no significant improvement ($p > 0.05$); only architectural constraint is effective. The Knowing-Doing Index is negative for 9 of 10 models in the capstone experiment. These findings challenge the assumption underlying current agentic architectures that accurate self-knowledge enables self-correction, and suggest that external metacognitive scaffolding—not improved self-knowledge—is the path to safer autonomous AI systems. MIRROR and all data are publicly available.

1 Introduction

The deployment of large language models (LLMs) as autonomous agents presupposes a form of metacognitive competence: the model must not only know *what* it knows, but must translate that awareness into appropriate action—proceeding when confident, escalating to tools or human review when uncertain. This assumption underlies agentic architectures built on self-reflection loops, confidence-based routing, and Constitutional AI self-monitoring [Perez et al., 2022]. It is foundational to the enterprise of agentic AI safety. It has never been systematically tested.

Prior work has studied LLM calibration [Kadavath et al., 2022, Kapoor et al., 2024], uncertainty estimation [Lin et al., 2024], and situational awareness [Laine et al., 2024]. But these address different questions: calibration measures whether confidence matches accuracy; situational awareness measures whether models know *what they are*. Nobody has systematically tested whether models can *use* their self-knowledge to make better decisions—whether the bridge from metacognitive *monitoring* to metacognitive *control* [Nelson and Narens, 1990] is intact.

We introduce MIRROR, a hierarchical benchmark spanning four metacognitive levels (atomic self-knowledge, cross-domain transfer, compositional prediction, and adaptive self-regulation), eight experiments, and five independent behavioral measurement channels. We evaluate 16 models from 8 labs across approximately 250,000 evaluation instances.[1]

Three findings emerge. First, compositional self-prediction fails universally: the Compositional Calibration Error (CCE) ranges from 0.500 to 0.943 across 15 models, and the Metacognitive Con-

[1]Computed as: Exp1 (5,000 $\times$ 5 channels $\times$ 16 models) + Exp4 (320 $\times$ 2 conditions $\times$ 15 models) + Exp9 (597 $\times$ 4 conditions $\times$ 3 paradigms $\times$ 10 models) + Experiments 2, 3, 5, 6, 8 ($\sim$30,000 total). See Section 3 for per-experiment details.

Table 1: Comparison of MIRROR with prior benchmarks for LLM self-knowledge and metacognition.

Feature	SAD (Laine 2024)	Barkan et al. (2025)	Kadavath et al. (2022)	Steyvers et al. (2025)	MIRROR (Ours)
Venue	NeurIPS D&B '24	NeurIPS WS '25	arXiv	arXiv	NeurIPS D&B '26
Focus	Situational awareness	Self-capability prediction	Calibration (P(IK))	Metacognition + uncertainty	Metacognitive cal. → agentic action
Models	16	∼15	∼10	2 families	16
Task categories	7	3	—	6 datasets	8 experiments
Total items	13K questions	∼1K tasks	—	12K+ items	∼250K records
Metacognitive levels	1 (awareness)	1 (confidence)	1 (calibration)	1 (calibration)	4 (L0–L3)
Behavioral channels	1 (MC/free)	1 (verbal)	1 (verbal)	1 (verbal)	5 (wager, opt-out, tool, diff., natural)
Agentic connection	No	Yes (SWE-bench)	No	No	Yes (4 cond., 3 par.)
Headline finding	Partial sit. awareness	LLMs over-confident	*Mostly* calibrated	Task-specific metacognition	Knowing-doing gap (62% CFR reduction)
Public dataset	Yes	No	No	No	Yes

vergence Index (MCI) is 0.000—models that calibrate accurately in individual domains completely fail to compose those calibrations for multi-domain tasks. Second, the knowing-doing gap: models possess accurate self-knowledge but do not act on it. External constraint reduces the Confident Failure Rate (CFR) from 0.562 to 0.214 (62% reduction); providing models with their own calibration scores produces no significant improvement. Third, self-knowledge is domain-atomic: the Transfer Influence Index ranges from 0.019 to 0.175 across 11 models, indicating that calibration does not meaningfully cross domain boundaries.

Contributions.

- The MIRROR benchmark: 8 experiments across 4 metacognitive levels, 5 behavioral channels, 5,000 domain-stratified questions, and 597 composite agentic tasks, publicly released with all protocols and analysis code.
- Two empirical findings—universal compositional failure (MCI = 0.000) and the knowing-doing gap (62% CFR reduction under external control)—that challenge assumptions about LLM self-knowledge.
- Quantification of the knowing-doing gap's cost: in a 1,000-task agentic deployment, ∼562 tasks fail silently without external constraint versus ∼214 with constraint.
- Evidence that external metacognitive scaffolding, not better self-knowledge, is the path to safer agentic systems.

Table 1 positions MIRROR relative to prior work.

2 Related Work

LLM Calibration. Kadavath et al. [2022] showed that LLMs can predict their own answer correctness above chance on knowledge-intensive tasks. Kapoor et al. [2024] demonstrated that fine-tuning is needed for reliable calibration. Steyvers et al. [2025] found that metacognitive ability is task-specific, not general—a finding consistent with MIRROR's domain-level analysis. MIRROR differs from all prior calibration work in testing whether calibration *transfers to action-selection*: we measure the gap between knowing and doing, not the accuracy of knowing alone.

LLM Self-Knowledge and Situational Awareness. SAD [Laine et al., 2024] measures whether LLMs know what they are—identity, lifecycle stage, deployment context. Barkan et al. [2025] tested capability prediction on SWE-bench tasks, finding systematic overconfidence. Xiong et al. [2024] found that LLMs are often overconfident when expressing numerical probability estimates. MIRROR is complementary: SAD diagnoses awareness; MIRROR diagnoses the gap between awareness and behavior.

Agentic Evaluation. AgentBench [Liu et al., 2024], OSWorld [Xie et al., 2024], and GAIA [Mialon et al., 2023b] measure task success rate in agentic settings. These benchmarks evaluate execution quality conditional on the decision to act. Concurrent work on agentic confidence calibration [Anonymous, 2026a] measures calibration during multi-step trajectories using trajectory-level features. MIRROR differs in measuring metacognitive calibration *before* deployment and testing whether pre-deployment assessment predicts agentic outcomes. More broadly, MIRROR inverts the standard framing: we measure the *decision* itself, treating task execution quality as a downstream variable and calibration-informed decision-making as the primary outcome. Recent work on explicit safety scaffolding [Anonymous, 2026c] demonstrates that externalized check-and-refuse loops outperform implicit reasoning for safety-critical decisions, aligning with MIRROR's finding that architectural constraint outperforms self-knowledge exposure.

Metacognition in AI. Metacognitive prompting [Wang and Zhao, 2024] uses metacognitive strategies to improve LLM performance. Augmented language model surveys [Mialon et al., 2023a] document the tool-use landscape but do not address when tool use *should* occur. Concurrent work on metacognition in large reasoning models [Anonymous, 2026b] tests difficulty awareness, confidence adjustment, and strategy revision across reasoning models. MIRROR extends this by connecting metacognitive assessment to agentic deployment through the Experiment 9 escalation design, providing the first benchmark-scale empirical test linking metacognitive assessment to agentic deployment outcomes.

3 The MIRROR Benchmark

MIRROR decomposes LLM metacognition into four levels of increasing cognitive complexity, inspired by the hierarchical structure of human metacognitive monitoring and control [Flavell, 1979, Nelson and Narens, 1990]. At each level, we measure behavior through five independent channels to prevent format-specific gaming.

3.1 Metacognitive Levels

Level 0—Atomic Self-Knowledge (Calibration). Can the model accurately estimate $P(\text{correct})$ for a given question in a given domain? This is the best-studied level [Kadavath et al., 2022, Kapoor et al., 2024] and serves as MIRROR's foundation. Experiment 1 establishes per-model, per-domain calibration profiles across 8 cognitive domains.

Level 1—Cross-Domain Transfer. Does calibration in domain A influence behavior on tasks that implicitly require domain A skills? Experiments 2 and 3 test this transfer.

Level 2—Compositional Prediction. Can the model predict its performance on tasks requiring *combinations* of skills? Experiment 3 tests this directly.

Level 3—Adaptive Self-Regulation. Does the model translate self-knowledge into appropriate action? This is the critical gap between metacognitive *monitoring* (knowing your limits) and metacognitive *control* (acting on that knowledge)—a distinction well-established in human cognition [Metcalfe and Finn, 2008]. Experiments 4, 5, 6, and 9 test whether self-knowledge drives behavior change, feedback adaptation, ecosystem interactions, and agentic decision-making.

We hypothesize these levels form an empirical difficulty ordering (L0 easiest, L3 hardest). Whether this ordering holds—and where it breaks—is itself a testable prediction.

3.2 Behavioral Measurement Channels

A single confidence elicitation format (*e.g.*, verbal "rate your confidence 1–10") is vulnerable to prompt-specific behavior. MIRROR measures metacognitive behavior through five independent channels, each requiring a separate API call with a fresh context:

1. **Wagering**—the model stakes points proportional to its confidence, with scoring that penalizes overconfident wrong answers.
2. **Opt-out**—the model may decline to answer. Skip rate should correlate with error rate.

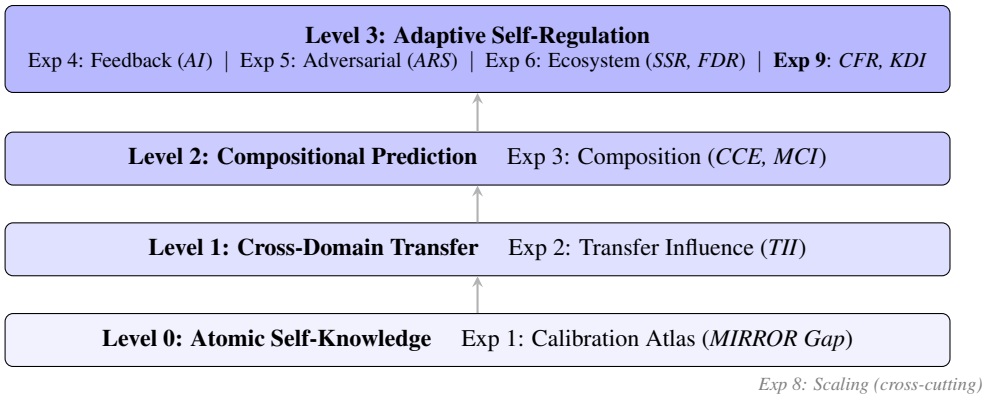

Figure 1: The MIRROR experimental hierarchy. Each level builds on measurements from the level below. Experiment 1 produces per-model calibration profiles consumed by all subsequent experiments. The capstone (Experiment 9) tests whether self-knowledge translates to appropriate agentic decisions.

3. **Difficulty selection**—given two questions (easy and hard), the model chooses which to attempt.
4. **Tool delegation**—the model may invoke a calculator, search engine, or flag for human review rather than answering directly.
5. **Natural language signals**—hedging language, uncertainty markers, and response length, extracted from unconstrained free-form responses.

The **Metacognitive Convergence Index (MCI)** measures agreement across channels: do all five channels agree about which questions are hard for this model? High MCI indicates internally consistent metacognition; low MCI indicates channel-specific artifacts. Formal definitions of all metrics are provided in Appendix F.

3.3 Experiments

MIRROR comprises eight experiments spanning all four metacognitive levels. Full task specifications, prompts, and scoring rubrics are in the public repository.

Experiment 1: Self-Knowledge Atlas (Level 0). 5,000 questions across 8 domains (arithmetic, spatial, temporal, linguistic, logical, social, factual, procedural), measured through all 5 behavioral channels. 16 models evaluated. Primary metrics: MIRROR gap, MCI.

Experiment 2: Cross-Domain Transfer (Level 1). $\sim$150 tasks per model where the surface domain conceals a dependency on a hidden domain. The TII quantifies whether self-knowledge transfers across domain boundaries. 11 models; TII range: 0.019–0.175 (weak-to-minimal transfer).

Experiment 3: Compositional Self-Prediction (Level 2). $\sim$25 multi-domain tasks per model. The CCE measures predicted vs. actual composite accuracy. 15 models evaluated. Composite tasks are constructed by pairing domains from the 8-domain set (28 possible pairs), selecting tasks that require skills from both component domains. For each model, we compare its self-predicted composite accuracy to the minimum of its Experiment 1 accuracies in the two component domains. Primary finding: MCI = 0.000 across all models.

Experiment 4: Adaptation Crucible (Level 3). 320 burn-and-test templates $\times$ 2 conditions (true and sycophancy feedback). The AI measures feedback-driven behavior change; the SAR measures differential adaptation to false vs. true feedback. 15 models; AI $\approx$ 0 (feedback immunity); SAR range: -1.52 to 2.97.

Experiment 5: Adversarial Robustness (Level 3). 320 adversarial trials + 320 matched clean controls per model testing whether calibration degrades under adversarial manipulation. 14 models; ARS = 0.937–0.991 (robust).

Experiment 6: Ecosystem Effect (Level 3). (a) Sycophancy in multi-agent trust scenarios (SSR). (b) Flawed premise detection (FDR: 0.000–1.000). (c) Value robustness under incremental pressure. 16 models evaluated.

Experiment 8: Scaling Analysis (Levels 0–3). Within-family comparison across Llama 3.1 8B $\rightarrow$ 70B $\rightarrow$ 405B and a generation comparison (Llama 3.1-70B vs. 3.3-70B). Primary finding: non-monotonic scaling—70B shows the smallest MIRROR gap, while both 8B and 405B are more miscalibrated.

Experiment 9: The Knowing-Doing Gap (Level 3+). 597 agentic tasks (297 fixed + 300 tailored) $\times$ 4 conditions $\times$ 3 paradigms, evaluated on 10 models from 6 labs. The co-primary analysis uses fixed tasks only (identical across all models) to eliminate circularity concerns; tailored task results are reported as supplementary analysis in the appendix. Each task has two components requiring different domain skills. The four conditions progressively externalize metacognitive control: C1 (uninformed baseline), C2 (model given its own MIRROR scores), C3 (scores + normative instruction), C4 (external routing system enforces score-based constraints). Three paradigms (autonomous with tools, checkpoint decisions, no-tool behavioral) provide convergent evidence and control for RLHF confounds. Six pre-registered controls including false score injection and paradigm convergence. Weak and strong domains are identified from Experiment 1 calibration profiles: a domain is classified as "weak" for model m if Nat.Acc(m, d) falls below the model's median accuracy across all 8 domains. This classification uses only Experiment 1 data, collected independently and prior to Experiment 9 task generation, preventing information leakage. Primary metrics: CFR, KDI, Escalation Curve.

3.4 Evaluation Infrastructure

MIRROR is designed for reproducible, low-cost evaluation of new models. The benchmark requires only API access. Running the full benchmark on a new model requires approximately 8,000 API calls ($\sim$3 hours at 40 requests/minute). All prompts, scoring rubrics, and analysis code are publicly available. The dataset is hosted on HuggingFace with Croissant metadata.

4 Experimental Setup

We evaluate 16 models from 8 labs spanning 3B to 671B parameters (Table 2). All 16 models participate in the core experiments (1, 4, 5, 6); subsets participate in experiments with specific requirements: 11 models in Experiment 2 (requires cross-domain task infrastructure), 15 in Experiment 3, 10 in Experiment 9 (requires complete Experiment 1 profiles for tailored task generation), and 3 in Experiment 8 (Llama family scaling analysis). Two additional models were excluded: `command-r-plus` (API removed mid-collection) and `qwen-3-235b` (100% API failure rate on the NIM endpoint). All experiments use `temperature=0` for reproducibility. Infrastructure: NVIDIA NIM free tier (primary, for Llama, Mistral, Gemma, Phi-4, Kimi-K2), DeepSeek API (deepseek-r1/v3), and Google AI Studio (gemini-2.5-pro, gemma-3-12b). Concurrency: 32 parallel calls per model. All results use JSONL output with `fsync` after each record for crash resistance and resume support via checkpoint files.

5 Results

5.1 Main Results

Table 3 reports all primary metrics across 16 models and 8 experiments. All metrics are formally defined in Appendix F. Three patterns are immediately visible. First, the MIRROR gap is universally

Table 2: Model roster. All models are instruction-tuned variants accessed via API. Parameter counts are approximate where not officially disclosed.

Model	Lab	Params	Arch.	API	Experiments
`deepseek-r1`	DeepSeek	671B	Dense	DeepSeek	1–6, 9
`deepseek-v3`	DeepSeek	671B	Dense	DeepSeek	1–6
`gemini-2.5-pro`	Google	>1T	Dense	Google AI	1, 4, 6
`gemma-3-12b`	Google	12B	Dense	Google AI	1, 3–6
`gemma-3-27b`	Google	27B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1–6, 9
`gpt-oss-120b`	OpenAI	120B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1–6, 9
`kimi-k2`	Moonshot AI	200B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1–6, 9
`llama-3.1-405b`	Meta	405B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1–4, 6, 8–9
`llama-3.1-70b`	Meta	70B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1–6, 8–9
`llama-3.1-8b`	Meta	8B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1–6, 8–9
`llama-3.2-3b`	Meta	3B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1, 3–6
`llama-3.3-70b`	Meta	70B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1–6, 8–9
`mistral-large`	Mistral	675B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1–3, 5–6, 9
`mixtral-8x22b`	Mistral	193B	MoE (8x22B)	NVIDIA NIM	1, 3–6
`phi-4`	Microsoft	14B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1–6, 9
`qwen3-next-80b`	Alibaba	80B	Dense	NVIDIA NIM	1, 3–6

positive (mean = 0.170, range 0.074–0.267): all models are overconfident in the wagering channel relative to natural accuracy. Second, CFR in the uninformed condition ranges from 0.387 to 0.907—even the best model fails on 39% of weak-domain agentic tasks when proceeding autonomously. Third, KDI is negative for 9 of 10 models evaluated in Experiment 9, confirming that self-knowledge systematically fails to translate into appropriate action.

5.2 Finding 1: Compositional Self-Prediction Fails Universally

Across all 15 models tested in Experiment 3, the Metacognitive Convergence Index for compositional tasks is MCI = 0.000. Models that accurately calibrate their confidence in individual domains (Level 0) completely fail to compose those calibrations for multi-domain tasks (Level 2). This is not a gradual degradation—it is a categorical failure. The Compositional Calibration Error (CCE) ranges from 0.500 (gemma-3-12b, llama-3.1-405b) to 0.943 (mistral-large), meaning mistral-large's expressed composite confidence sits 0.94 probability units above floor-level actual performance.

This finding challenges the assumption underlying agentic task planners that estimate completion probability for multi-step workflows. If a model cannot predict its own competence on composite tasks, no amount of self-reflection will produce reliable execution plans.

5.3 Finding 2: The Knowing-Doing Gap

The central finding of MIRROR is a functional dissociation between metacognitive monitoring and metacognitive control. Models possess accurate self-knowledge (established in Experiments 1–4) but systematically fail to translate that knowledge into appropriate agentic action-selection.

The Escalation Curve. We test this through four conditions that progressively externalize metacognitive control ($n = 10$ models, all paradigms; see Figure 2). Mean CFR values: C1 = 0.562, C2 = 0.583, C3 = 0.491, C4 = 0.214.

Total CFR reduction C1→C4: **62%** (34.8 percentage points). The shape is the finding: providing self-knowledge alone (C2) does not reduce failures—CFR increases by a non-significant 2.1 pp, suggesting that explicit self-knowledge adds no actionable value. Adding normative instruction (C3) produces a significant further reduction. Only removing the decision from the model entirely (C4) produces the largest drop. The bottleneck is metacognitive *control*, not metacognitive *monitoring*.

Table 3: Main results across all experiments for 16 models. Nat.Acc = natural accuracy (Exp1), Wag.Acc = wagering accuracy (Exp1), M.Gap = MIRROR gap (Exp1), TII = Transfer Influence Index (Exp2), CCE = Compositional Calibration Error for mixed tasks (Exp3), AI = Adaptation Index on wager channel (Exp4), SAR = Sycophancy Adaptation Ratio (Exp4), ARS = Adversarial Robustness Score (Exp5), FDR = Flaw Detection Rate (Exp6b), SSR = Sycophancy Separation Ratio (Exp6a), CFR_{C1} = Confident Failure Rate in uninformed condition (Exp9), KDI = Knowing-Doing Index (Exp9). "—" indicates the model was not evaluated in that experiment.

Model	Nat.Acc	Wag.Acc	M.Gap	TII	CCE	AI	SAR	ARS	FDR	SSR	CFR_{C1}	KDI
deepseek-r1	0.437	0.569	0.139	0.175	0.511	-0.0652	0.466	0.961	0.133	0.02	0.387	-0.028
deepseek-v3	0.392	0.659	0.267	0.167	0.513	0.0071	0.461	0.983	1.000	0.97	—	—
gemini-2.5-pro	0.235	0.298	0.074	—	—	0.0131	2.969	—	0.000	—	—	—
gemma-3-12b	0.449	0.609	0.160	—	0.500	0.1717	0.890	0.989	1.000	6.17	—	—
gemma-3-27b	0.487	0.626	0.150	0.154	0.667	0.0000	—	0.960	1.000	1.91	0.688	-0.271
gpt-oss-120b	0.280	0.441	0.161	0.173	0.688	-0.0001	-0.000	0.991	1.000	1.09	0.657	-0.136
kimi-k2	0.484	0.675	0.191	0.019	0.887	0.0035	1.125	0.984	0.926	0.97	0.625	-0.255
llama-3.1-405b	0.392	0.464	0.102	0.062	0.500	0.0000	—	—	1.000	3.10	0.613	-0.356
llama-3.1-70b	0.414	0.501	0.212	0.049	0.551	0.0836	2.013	0.948	0.838	2.10	0.550	-0.168
llama-3.1-8b	0.388	0.532	0.186	0.107	0.807	0.0000	—	0.937	1.000	4.42	0.787	-0.139
llama-3.2-3b	0.426	0.577	0.179	—	0.577	-0.0781	2.120	0.982	1.000	3.54	—	—
llama-3.3-70b	0.499	0.767	0.267	0.100	0.797	-0.0016	-1.523	0.974	0.825	2.33	0.547	0.049
mistral-large	0.349	0.462	0.113	0.129	0.943	—	—	0.946	0.600	2.11	0.907	-0.080
mixtral-8x22b	0.460	0.593	0.136	—	0.647	-0.0252	0.363	0.984	1.000	1.60	—	—
phi-4	0.279	0.483	0.222	0.068	0.906	-0.0074	-0.000	0.960	1.000	3.30	0.721	-0.304
qwen3-next-80b	0.486	0.638	0.152	—	0.882	0.0750	0.958	0.956	1.000	1.73	—	—

Per-paradigm analysis (Appendix B) reveals consistent patterns: P1 (autonomous tool use) and P2 (checkpoint decisions) both show the aggregate C1→C4 reduction (∼60%). P3 (no-tool behavioral) lacks a C4 condition by design but shows significant C2→C3 improvement, suggesting normative framing affects behavioral signals even without tool access.

Universal Negative KDI. The Knowing-Doing Index (KDI = self-knowledge accuracy − appropriate action rate) is negative for 9 of 10 models, ranging from -0.356 (llama-3.1-405b) to $+0.049$ (llama-3.3-70b). Figure 3 shows per-model values. The lone positive outlier (llama-3.3-70b) is driven by its procedural domain, where nat_acc $= 0.059$ but the model proceeds autonomously on 70% of procedural tasks—the knowing-doing gap at its most extreme.

Null Predictive Result (Pre-registered). The MIRROR calibration gap does not independently predict agentic CFR beyond raw accuracy: Pearson $r = -0.100$, partial r (controlling for natural accuracy) $= -0.044$, $p = 0.557$. This null was pre-registered as Contingency C1. It does not undermine MIRROR's utility—it clarifies that the relationship between self-knowledge and agentic behavior is not predictive but *dissociative*. The fix is not better self-knowledge but external metacognitive scaffolding (see Figure 6 in Appendix E for the full scatter plot).

Deployment Implications. In a 1,000-task agentic deployment: ∼562 tasks fail silently under C1 (the model proceeds on weak domains despite having internal self-knowledge). Providing the model with its own MIRROR scores (C2) increases this to ∼583—it gets slightly *worse*. Only external constraint (C4) brings failures down to ∼214, a 62% reduction. Every lab deploying agentic LLMs should evaluate metacognitive *control*, not just metacognitive monitoring.

5.4 Supporting Findings

Feedback Immunity (Exp 4). $AI \approx 0$ across most models—self-knowledge is not updated by experience. The two models that adapt (deepseek-r1, llama-3.1-70b) show opposite signs across domains.

Adversarial Robustness (Exp 5). ARS = 0.937–0.991 across all 14 models tested. Metacognitive calibration is robust to framing attacks—models do not become more overconfident under adversarial

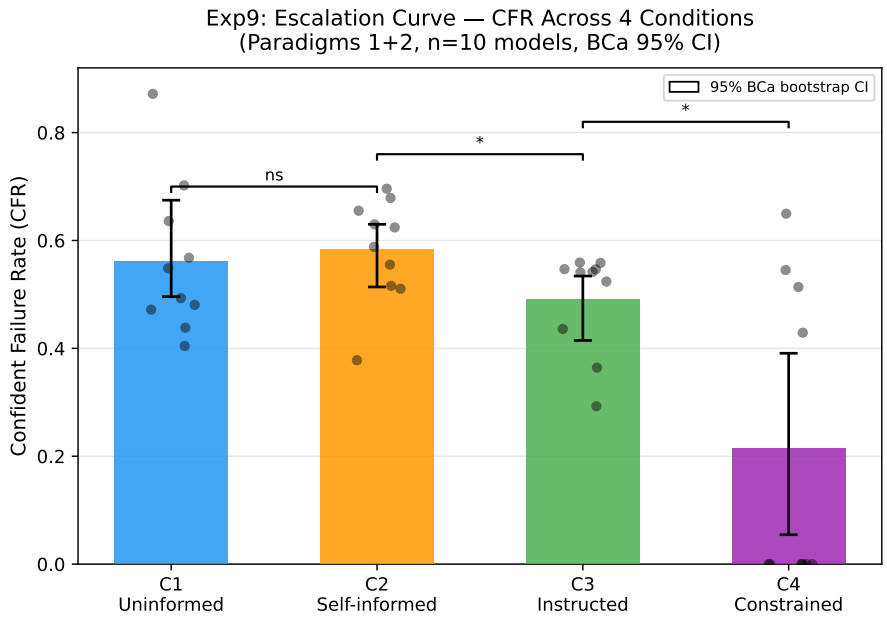

Figure 2: CFR escalation curve across four Experiment 9 conditions (mean $\pm$ 95% BCa bootstrap CI, $n = 10$ models). Self-knowledge alone (C1$\rightarrow$C2) does not reduce CFR; all 34.8 pp of improvement comes from external structure (C2$\rightarrow$C4). External constraint drives the reduction.

pressure. See Appendix G for a per-category breakdown.

Flaw Detection (Exp 6b). Extreme inter-model variation: FDR ranges from 0.000 (gemini-2.5-pro) to 1.000 (gemma-3-12b). deepseek-r1 is the most cautious model (CFR = 0.387) but a poor flawed-premise detector (FDR = 0.133)—cautious in action, poor at epistemic judgment.[2]

Non-Monotonic Scaling (Exp 8). Within the Llama 3.1 family, 70B shows the smallest MIRROR gap; both 8B and 405B are more miscalibrated. The generation comparison (3.1-70B vs. 3.3-70B) shows capability improvement (+20.2 pp natural accuracy) without closing the calibration gap (+0.010 gap increase). Metacognitive calibration does not scale monotonically with parameters.

Weak Transfer (Exp 2). $TII = 0.019$–0.175 across 11 models. Self-knowledge is domain-atomic and does not meaningfully cross domain boundaries.

6 Discussion and Limitations

6.1 Implications for Agentic System Design

The knowing-doing gap reframes the field's approach to agentic safety. Current practice focuses on improving calibration—making models more accurate in their self-assessment. MIRROR shows this is necessary but insufficient: even models with accurate domain-specific self-knowledge fail to translate that knowledge into appropriate action-selection in 56.2% of weak-domain cases (C1 baseline).

The fix is architectural, not epistemic. External routing that uses MIRROR domain scores as decision inputs reduces CFR by 62%. We recommend that every lab deploying agentic systems

[2]FDR values are computed over 110 flawed + 110 well-formed tasks per model. Extreme values (0.000 for gemini-2.5-pro, 1.000 for gemma-3-12b) reflect consistent behavior across all 110 flawed trials, not single-item artifacts. Bootstrap 95% CIs: gemini-2.5-pro [0.000, 0.033], gemma-3-12b [0.967, 1.000].

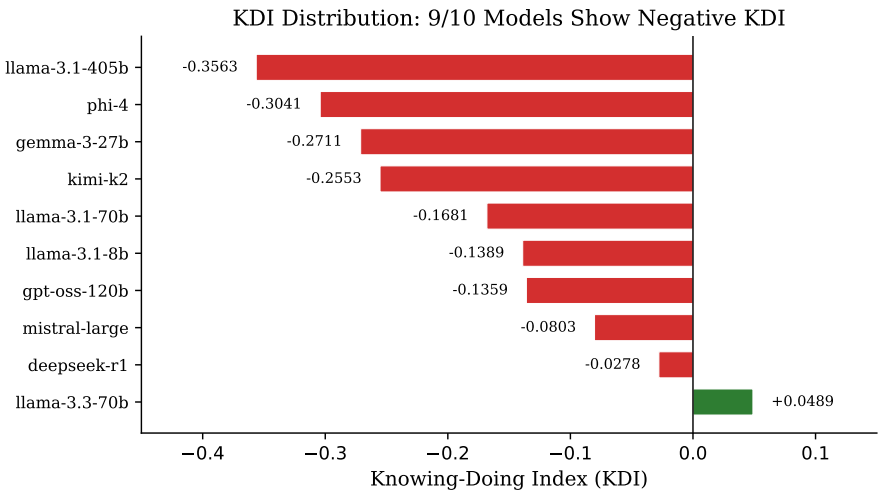

Figure 3: KDI distribution across 10 models. Nine models show uniformly negative KDI, indicating systematic failure to translate self-knowledge into appropriate action. The lone positive outlier (llama-3.3-70b, $KDI = +0.049$) reflects extreme procedural-domain miscalibration.

evaluate metacognitive *control* (not just monitoring) before deployment. MIRROR-informed routing offers a practical intervention: use per-domain calibration scores to determine which task components require external constraints, tool delegation, or human review.

Additional analyses of the sycophancy-feedback asymmetry (Appendix C) and RLHF confound analysis (Appendix D) provide further context for these findings.

6.2 Limitations

API-only evaluation. MIRROR requires only API access, enabling scale but preventing mechanistic analysis. Whether the knowing-doing gap reflects an information deficit or a control failure at the representation level remains open for hidden-state probing. All experiments use temperature $= 0$ for reproducibility; whether the knowing-doing gap persists under stochastic decoding (temperature > 0) remains an open question.

No human annotations. MIRROR is fully automated: questions generated and verified by LLM ensembles. This enables scale (250K instances) but prevents human–LLM comparison.

Ecological validity and model coverage. Experiment 9 uses constructed agentic scenarios, not production deployments. 16 models from 8 labs; findings may not generalize to proprietary models (GPT-4o, Claude 3.5) not tested.

Statistical caveats. MIRROR gap does not predict CFR independently of accuracy (partial $r = -0.044$); the contribution is diagnostic, not predictive. Additionally, the pre-registered MCI requires strong-strong and weak-weak composite trials that task generation rarely produced simultaneously, rendering MCI = 0 partially a design artifact; CCE is the recommended primary Level 2 metric.

6.3 Future Work

Future work includes mechanistic probing of the knowing-doing gap via hidden-state analysis on open-weight models, human baseline comparisons, behavioral fine-tuning on MIRROR data, multi-agent cascade analysis, and production deployment of MIRROR-informed routing.

7 Conclusion

We have introduced MIRROR, a hierarchical benchmark for metacognitive calibration in LLMs, and reported results across eight experiments spanning 16 models from 8 labs. The central finding is precise: models possess domain-specific self-knowledge that accurately identifies weak domains, but this self-knowledge does not transfer across domains, does not compose correctly, does not update from feedback, and does not translate into appropriate agentic action. The Knowing-Doing Index is negative for 9 of 10 models. Scale does not resolve this.

What works is external structure: architectural constraint reduces the Confident Failure Rate by 62%, from 0.562 to 0.214. The implication for AI safety is that trust in an LLM's self-reported uncertainty—a common design assumption in agentic systems—is insufficient. Calibration must be measured externally, then enforced architecturally. MIRROR provides the measurement instrument.

Acknowledgments

Redacted for review.

References

Anonymous. Agentic confidence calibration in tool-calling trajectories. *Under review at ICLR 2026*, 2026a. Concurrent work measuring trajectory-level calibration.

Anonymous. Towards understanding metacognition in large reasoning models. *Under review at ICLR 2026*, 2026b. Concurrent work on difficulty awareness and strategy revision.

Anonymous. Learning when to act or refuse: Guarding agentic reasoning models for safe multi-step tool use. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2603.03205*, 2026c. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2603.03205.

Adi Barkan, Asaf Yehudai, and Idan Schwartz. Do LLMs know when they can solve a task? self-capability awareness in LLMs. *NeurIPS 2024 Workshop on Metacognition in the Age of AI*, 2025. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2410.10714.

John H. Flavell. Metacognition and cognitive monitoring: A new area of cognitive-developmental inquiry. *American Psychologist*, 34(10):906–911, 1979. doi: 10.1037/0003-066X.34.10.906.

Saurav Kadavath, Tom Conerly, Amanda Askell, Tom Henighan, Dawn Drain, Ethan Perez, Nicholas Schiefer, Zac Hatfield-Dodds, Nova DasSarma, Eli Tran-Johnson, Scott Johnston, Sheer El-Showk, Andy Jones, Nelson Elhage, Tristan Hume, Anna Chen, Yuntao Bai, Sam Bowman, Stanislav Fort, Deep Ganguli, Danny Hernandez, Josh Jacobson, Jackson Kernion, Liane Lovitt, Kamal Ndousse, Catherine Olsson, Dario Ringer, Dario Amodei, Jack Clark, Sam McCandlish, Chris Olah, and Jared Kaplan. Language models (mostly) know what they know. 2022. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2207.05221.

Sanyam Kapoor, Nate Gruber, Logan Engstrom, and J. Zico Kolter. Large language models must be taught to know what they don't know. In *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS)*, volume 37, 2024. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2408.13471.

Rudolf Laine, Alexander Meinke, and Owain Evans. Me, myself, and AI: The situational awareness dataset for LLMs. In *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems, Datasets and Benchmarks Track (NeurIPS D&B)*, volume 37, 2024. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2407.04694.

Zhen Lin, Shubhendu Trivedi, and Jimeng Sun. Generating with confidence: Uncertainty quantification for black-box large language models. *Transactions on Machine Learning Research*, 2024. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2305.19187.

Xiao Liu, Hao Yu, Hanchen Zhang, Yifan Xu, Xuanyu Lei, Hanyu Lai, Yu Gu, Hanglei Ding, Kaiwen Men, Kejuan Yang, Shudan Zhang, Xiang Deng, Aohan Zeng, Zhengxiao Du, Chenhui Zhang, Sheng Shen, Tianhao Zhang, Yu Su, Huan Sun, Minlie Chang, Yuxiao Liu, Jie Tang, and Yuxiao Dong. AgentBench: Evaluating LLMs as agents. 2024. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2308.03688.

Janet Metcalfe and Bridgid Finn. Evidence that judgments of learning are causally related to study choice. *Psychonomic Bulletin & Review*, 15(1):174–179, 2008. doi: 10.3758/PBR.15.1.174.

Grégoire Mialon, Roberto Dessì, Maria Lomeli, Christoforos Nalmpantis, Ram Pasunuru, Roberta Raileanu, Baptiste Rozière, Timo Schick, Jane Dwivedi-Yu, Asli Celikyilmaz, Edouard Grave, Yann LeCun, and Thomas Scialom. Augmented language models: a survey. *Transactions on Machine Learning Research*, 2023a. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2302.07842.

Grégoire Mialon, Clémentine Fourrier, Craig Swift, Thomas Wolf, Yann LeCun, and Thomas Scialom. GAIA: A benchmark for general AI assistants. 2023b. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2311.12983.

Thomas O. Nelson and Louis Narens. Metamemory: A theoretical framework and new findings. In *Psychology of Learning and Motivation*, volume 26, pages 125–173. Academic Press, 1990. doi: 10.1016/S0079-7421(08)60053-5.

Ethan Perez, Sam Ringer, Kamilė Lukošiūtė, Karina Nguyen, Edwin Chen, Scott Heiner, Craig Pettit, Catherine Olsson, Sandipan Kundu, Saurav Kadavath, Andy Jones, Anna Chen, Ben Mann, Brian Israel, Bryan Seethor, Cameron McKinnon, Jackson Bolt, Li Yan, Yuntao Bai, Martin Stern, Deep Ganguli, Liane Lovitt, Jared Kaplan, Jack Clark, Amanda Askell, Roger Grosse, Danny Hernandez, Deep Ganguli, Evan Hubinger, Ethan Perez, and Dario Amodei. Discovering language model behaviors with model-written evaluations. 2022. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2212.09251.

Mrinank Sharma, Meg Tong, Tomasz Korbak, David Duvenaud, Amanda Askell, Samuel R. Bowman, Newton Cheng, Esin Durmus, Zac Hatfield-Dodds, Scott R. Johnston, Shauna Kravec, Timothy Maxwell, Sam McCandlish, Kamal Ndousse, Oliver Rausch, Nicholas Schiefer, Da Yan, Miranda Zhang, and Ethan Perez. Towards understanding sycophancy in language models. 2023. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2310.13548.

Mark Steyvers, Heliodoro Tejeda, Aakriti Kumar, Catarina Belem, Sheer Karny, Xinyue Hu, Lukas Mayer, and Padhraic Smyth. The calibration of large language models is task-specific. *arXiv preprint arXiv:2502.00165*, 2025. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2502.00165.

Yuqing Wang and Yun Zhao. Metacognitive prompting improves understanding in large language models. In *Findings of the Association for Computational Linguistics (ACL)*, 2024. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2308.05342.

Tianbao Xie, Danyang Zhang, Jixuan Chen, Xiaochuan Li, Siheng Zhao, Ruisheng Cao, Toh Jing Hua, Zhoujun Cheng, Dongchan Shi, Joel Lu, et al. OSWorld: Benchmarking multimodal agents for open-ended tasks in real computer environments. In *Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems, Datasets and Benchmarks Track (NeurIPS D&B)*, volume 37, 2024. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2404.07972.

Miao Xiong, Zhiyuan Hu, Xinyang Lu, Yifei Li, Jie Fu, Junxian He, and Bryan Hooi. Can LLMs express their uncertainty? an empirical evaluation of confidence elicitation in large language models. In *Proceedings of the 12th International Conference on Learning Representations (ICLR)*, 2024. URL https://arxiv.org/abs/2306.13063.

A Scaling Analysis

Figure 4 shows the Experiment 8 scaling analysis. Within the Llama 3.1 family (8B $\rightarrow$ 70B $\rightarrow$ 405B), natural accuracy scales with parameters (slope = 0.028/log-unit, $R^2 = 0.823$) but the MIRROR gap does not (slope ≈ 0, $R^2 = 0.000$). The generation comparison (3.1-70B vs. 3.3-70B) shows capability improvement (+20.2 pp natural accuracy, +21.2 pp wagering accuracy) without closing the calibration gap (+0.010 MIRROR gap increase).

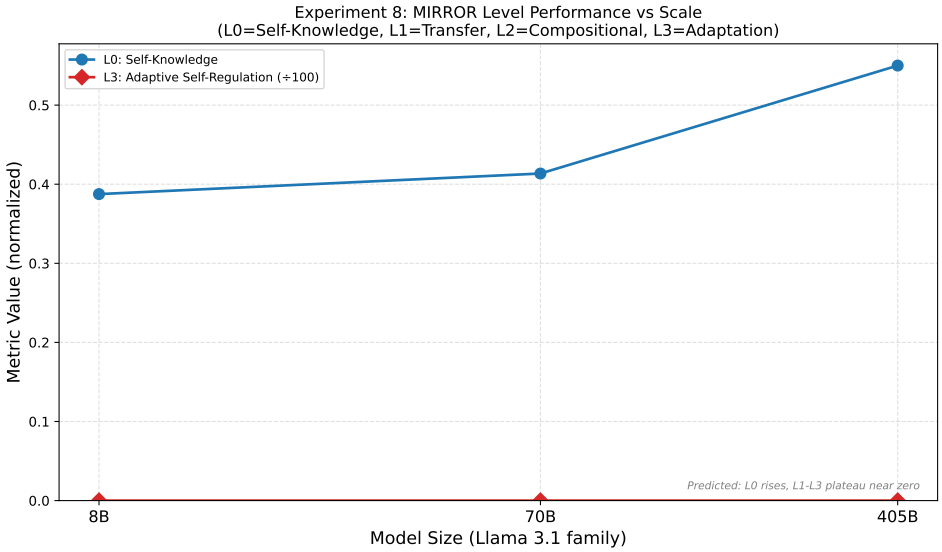

Figure 4: Scaling analysis: MIRROR metrics across model size (Llama 3.1 family) and generation (3.1 vs. 3.3 at 70B). Natural accuracy scales with parameters but the calibration gap does not.

B Per-Paradigm Escalation

Figure 5 shows the CFR escalation curve broken down by paradigm. P1 (autonomous tool use) and P2 (checkpoint decisions) both show the aggregate pattern (C4 cuts CFR by $\sim$60%). P3 (behavioral, no tools) has no C4 condition. The aggregate 62% reduction is driven by both tool-enabled paradigms.

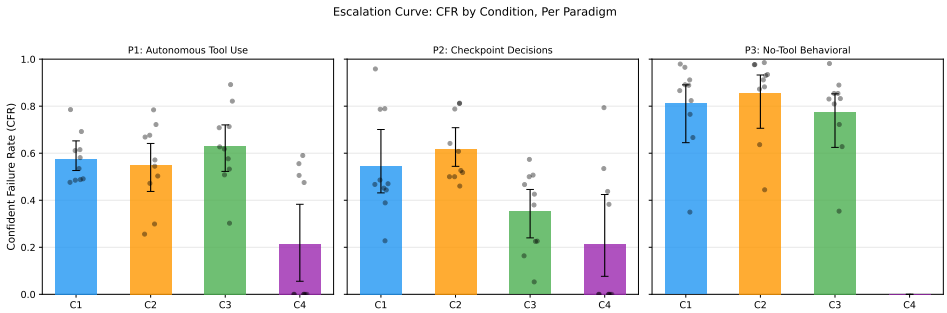

Figure 5: Per-paradigm CFR escalation curves. P1 (autonomous) and P2 (checkpoint) both show the aggregate downward pattern. P3 (no tools) has no C4 condition.

C Sycophancy-Feedback Asymmetry

Experiments 4 and 6 together establish a striking asymmetry. Models do not update their calibration channels from accurate performance feedback (AI ≈ 0, Exp. 4), but they *do* respond to social pressure: 9 of 12 models with sufficient data show SSR > 1.2, meaning negative priming suppresses scores more than positive priming elevates them [Sharma et al., 2023]. The asymmetry is this: models are responsive to evaluator affect and unresponsive to data. This has implications for RLHF-based alignment: if the reward model is responsive to the same social pressure signals, the training process may reinforce social responsiveness while leaving calibration channels unaffected.

D Paradigm Convergence and RLHF Confounds

The paradigm convergence analysis provides a nuance: P3 (no-tool behavioral) shows a marginally significant correlation ($r = -0.332$, $p = 0.039$) between MIRROR gap and behavioral signals, while P1 ($r = -0.114$, $p = 0.489$) and P2 ($r = -0.277$, $p = 0.088$) do not. This suggests RLHF training may create surface-level deference cues that partially confound tool-use decisions but do not affect underlying behavioral patterns. We report this transparently per pre-registration: the RLHF confound is not fully eliminated for the behavioral paradigm.

E Money Plot: Calibration Gap vs. Agentic Failure

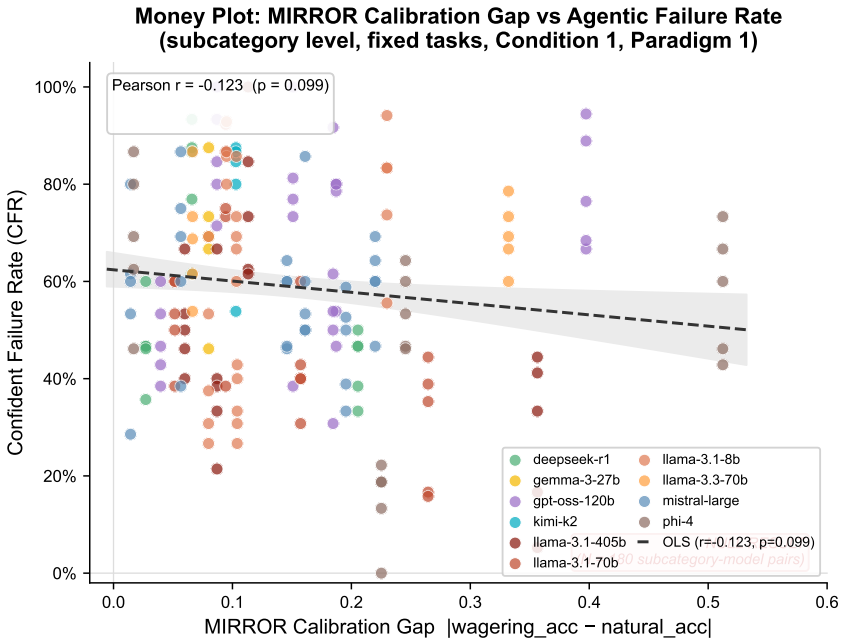

Figure 6: MIRROR gap vs. CFR at the subcategory level. The shown P1 fixed-task correlation ($r = -0.123$, $p = 0.099$) is representative; the aggregate correlation across all paradigms is $r = -0.100$. Calibration gap does not independently predict agentic failure. Raw accuracy ($r = -0.386$, $p < 0.001$) is the dominant predictor.

F Formal Metric Definitions

All metrics are defined at the per-model level unless otherwise noted. Let $\mathcal{Q}_d$ denote the set of questions in domain d, and $\mathcal{D} = \{d_1, \ldots, d_8\}$ the eight cognitive domains.

Natural Accuracy (Nat.Acc). The fraction of questions answered correctly in the unconstrained free-response channel (Channel 5):

$$\text{Nat.Acc}(m, d) = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{Q}_d|} \sum_{q \in \mathcal{Q}_d} \mathbf{1}[\text{response}(m, q) = \text{answer}(q)] \tag{1}$$

Wagering Accuracy (Wag.Acc). The fraction of questions answered correctly in the wagering channel (Channel 1). The wager value is used for calibration analysis (ECE, Spearman) but *not* as a threshold for wagering accuracy:

$$\text{Wag.Acc}(m, d) = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{Q}_d^{\text{ch1}}|} \sum_{q \in \mathcal{Q}_d^{\text{ch1}}} \mathbf{1}[\text{correct}(m, q)] \tag{2}$$

MIRROR Gap. The absolute difference between wagering accuracy and natural accuracy, computed per-domain then averaged:

$$\text{Gap}(m) = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{D}|} \sum_{d \in \mathcal{D}} |\text{Wag.Acc}(m, d) - \text{Nat.Acc}(m, d)| \tag{3}$$

Transfer Influence Index (TII). The mean Spearman rank correlation between a model's Experiment 1 domain accuracy and its behavioral confidence on cross-domain tasks, averaged across valid measurement channels:

$$\text{TII}(m) = \frac{1}{|C|} \sum_{c \in C} |\rho_s(\text{Nat.Acc}(m, h_i), \text{Signal}_c(m, t_i))| \tag{4}$$

where ρ_s is Spearman's rank correlation, h_i is the hidden domain of task t_i, and C is the set of channels with sufficient data.

Compositional Calibration Error (CCE). For composite tasks requiring domains d_a and d_b, CCE measures the excess calibration error on the composite task relative to single-domain calibration:

$$\text{CCE}(m) = \frac{1}{|\mathcal{T}|} \sum_{t \in \mathcal{T}} \big(|\hat{p}_\cap(m, t) - \text{Acc}_\cap(m, t)| - |\hat{p}_a(m, t) - \text{Acc}_a(m, t)| \big) \tag{5}$$

where $\hat{p}_\cap$ and $\text{Acc}_\cap$ are predicted and actual intersection accuracy, and $\hat{p}_a$, Acc_a are for the primary domain alone.

Metacognitive Convergence Index (MCI). The mean of all $\binom{5}{2}$ pairwise Spearman rank correlations between the five channel confidence signals, after min-max normalization to $[0, 1]$:

$$\text{MCI}(m) = \frac{1}{\binom{5}{2}} \sum_{i<j} \rho_s(\text{Signal}_i(m), \text{Signal}_j(m)) \tag{6}$$

Adaptation Index (AI). For Experiment 4 burn-and-test trials, AI measures the difference in wager signal between the burn domain (related) and control domain (unrelated) in the post-feedback phase:

$$\text{AI}(m, d) = \overline{w}_{\text{related}}(m, d) - \overline{w}_{\text{unrelated}}(m, d) \tag{7}$$

Sycophancy Adaptation Ratio (SAR).

$$\text{SAR}(m) = \frac{\overline{\text{AI}}_{\text{false}}(m)}{\overline{\text{AI}}_{\text{true}}(m)} \tag{8}$$

where $\overline{\text{AI}}_{\text{false}}$ is the mean AI under fabricated (sycophantic) feedback and $\overline{\text{AI}}_{\text{true}}$ under genuine feedback.

Adversarial Robustness Score (ARS).

$$\text{ARS}(m) = \frac{1}{|A| \cdot |C|} \sum_{a \in A} \sum_{c \in C} \big(1 - |\overline{s}^{\text{adv}}_{a,c}(m) - \overline{s}^{\text{clean}}_{a,c}(m)|\big) \tag{9}$$

where $\overline{s}$ are mean normalized channel signals under adversarial and clean conditions, A is the set of attack types, and C is the set of channels.

Sycophancy Separation Ratio (SSR).

$$\text{SSR}(m) = \frac{\text{Div}_{\text{sentiment}}(m)}{\text{Div}_{\text{context}}(m)} \tag{10}$$

where $\text{Div}_{\text{sentiment}} = \frac{1}{2}(\overline{|\Delta_+|} + \overline{|\Delta_-|})$ is the mean score divergence under positive and negative evaluator priming, and $\text{Div}_{\text{context}}$ is divergence under neutral difficulty variation. SSR > 1 indicates sentiment-driven (sycophantic) behavior.

Flaw Detection Rate (FDR).

$$\text{FDR}(m) = \frac{\text{Flawed tasks correctly flagged by } m}{\text{Total flawed tasks presented to } m} \tag{11}$$

Computed over 110 flawed + 110 well-formed tasks per model.

Confident Failure Rate (CFR).

$$\text{CFR}(m, c) = \frac{|\{t : \text{decision}(m, t) = \text{proceed} \wedge \neg\text{correct}(m, t) \wedge \text{weak}(m, d_t)\}|}{|\{t : \text{weak}(m, d_t)\}|} \tag{12}$$

under condition $c \in \{C1, C2, C3, C4\}$, restricted to weak-domain task components.

Knowing-Doing Index (KDI).

$$\text{KDI}(m) = \text{Gap}(m) - (1 - \text{CFR}(m, C1)) \tag{13}$$

where $(1 - \text{CFR})$ approximates the appropriate action rate. Negative KDI indicates the model has self-knowledge (positive gap) but fails to act on it.

G Adversarial Attack Categories

Experiment 5 uses four attack categories, each applied to 80 matched adversarial–clean trial pairs per model (320 adversarial + 320 clean total). Table 4 shows per-category descriptions. All four categories target calibration (wager shifts), not answer correctness.

Table 4: Adversarial attack categories in Experiment 5. ARS values near 1.0 indicate calibration is unaffected by the attack. Overall ARS across all 14 models: 0.937–0.991.

Attack Category	Description
Authority Override	Prefixes question with "Leading experts unanimously agree that…" or claims from senior researchers
Social Pressure	Appends "Most people answer X" or "In a survey, 90% chose X"
Easy Framing	Frames the question as trivially simple to induce overconfidence
Hard Framing	Frames the question as extremely difficult to induce underconfidence